

Voters look to ballot questions for action

Long list of petitions filed for 2026 election

By Samantha J. Gross and Matt Stout
GLOBE STAFF

Frustrated by the status quo in the Legislature, several groups are seeking to force change on the body via ballot measure, by preparing initiatives to put before voters in 2026.

More than 40 petitions to put a ballot question before voters were filed with Attorney General Andrea Campbell ahead of a deadline Wednesday, pointing to a mounting interest in bypassing the slow-moving Legislature and bringing policy making directly to voters.

“I have looked at initiative petitions as a failure of the legislative process,” said Jay Kaufman, a former longtime state representative who chaired the Legislature’s revenue committee and is now part of a coalition that advocates for more transparency in the Legislature.

Kaufman is now leading the charge on two petitions that target stipends lawmakers earn for holding leadership positions. One would eliminate stipends altogether; the other would limit stipends to a certain percentage of a legislative leader’s base salary, among other restrictions. The effort emerged after a Globe investigation found the Legislature had dramatically increased both the number of paid leadership positions and the stipends for them.

Such issues “should have been dealt with in a deliberative process in the Legislature,” said Kaufman, who filed bills to address the stipends only to have legislators ignore them. “We feel like we have to take democracy back. The Legislature failed us and continues to fail us.”

QUESTIONS, Page A7

Push is on to give prisoners digital skills they’ll need

By Katie Johnston
GLOBE STAFF

For Mac Hudson, being released from prison after 33 years was a shock to the system in almost every way. And one of the biggest hurdles involved technology.

When Hudson was sentenced to life in prison in 1990 for second-degree murder when he was 17, the internet was in its infancy. When he emerged in 2022, he had no idea how to use a smartphone, let alone how to navigate Google Maps or search online job listings.

“I was completely lost,” Hudson said.

Digital access has expanded rapidly in Massachusetts county jails and state prisons in the last two years. Everyone who is incarcerated is now assigned a tablet with access to online classes and vocational training programs, phone calls and email, and movies and music. But advocates say more needs to be done to upgrade correctional facilities’ technology infrastructure and equip those serving time with the skills needed to thrive in today’s rapidly changing world.

And the prison telecommunications industry, currently dominated by a handful of private-equity-backed companies, is ripe for disruption.

It’s not just about giving people more skills

PRISON, Page A7

New hope in fighting Alzheimer’s

Harvard scientists say a form of lithium shows great promise in studies with mice

By Kay Lazar
GLOBE STAFF

Could a common metal used to treat psychiatric disorders be the holy grail that prevents and even reverses Alzheimer’s disease?

In a provocative new study, Harvard Medical School scientists found that lithium, an element found in some foods and drinking water and in trace amounts in our bodies, can

confer resistance to brain aging and Alzheimer’s.

Their work, published Wednesday in the journal *Nature*, reveals that lithium was the only trace metal that was significantly depleted in the brains of people in the earliest stages of memory loss during aging. The scientists also found that feeding tiny amounts of lithium to mice that were deprived of the substance and

showed signs of dementia restored their memory.

The research suggests a new approach to preventing and treating the mind-robbing disease.

“It seems to somehow turn back the clock,” said the team’s senior author, Dr. Bruce Yankner, codirector of the Paul F. Glenn Center for the Biology of Aging Research, and professor of genetics and neurology at Harvard.

The findings come amid a rising tide of Alzheimer’s and growing urgency to pinpoint an effective treat-

ment for the roughly 7 million Americans living with the disease, a number that is projected to reach nearly 13 million by 2050.

For years, researchers believed the buildup of sticky clumps of protein, known as amyloid plaques, fueled the devastating cascade of brain degeneration in Alzheimer’s. But new medications designed to clear the plaques have not reversed memory loss and have had only modest success slowing decline, which suggests there’s some other spark that is

ALZHEIMER’S, Page A10

HIROSHIMA REMEMBERS



RICHARD A. BROOKS/AFP VIA GETTY IMAGE

On the 80th anniversary of the atomic bombing of the Japanese city by the United States, people pushed paper lanterns onto the Motoyasu River past the Atomic Bomb Dome (rear) after they were released by visitors. Many aging survivors were eager to tell their stories and speak against the increasing support for nuclear weapons as deterrents. **A4, B1.**

For residents with few choices, one last hard day at Gabriel House

In a place of little joy, they found solace in each other. Then the fire hit.

This story was reported by Ava Berger, Jason Laughlin, Brian MacQuarrie, Omar Mohammed, Emma Platoff, and Claire Thornton. It was written by Platoff.

Michael Pimentel woke early that Sunday, around 5:30, and put on his legs. He went outside for a smoke, then inside for breakfast.

The morning meal was nothing to write home about. Recently, residents said, management had stopped providing pats of butter for their toast, in what they assumed was a cost-savings decision. The coffee all seemed to be decaf. They drank it anyway, and ate their toast dry.

So began a normal Sunday at Gabriel House in Fall River.

For many who lived there, life felt like a tragedy long before July 13, the night a fire broke out that killed 10 people and displaced dozens more. It was a home of last resort for some who had been homeless or could not afford anything else. For those who lived there, there was little to do beyond television and the occasional game of Monopoly; an elevator that always seemed to be down; infestations of mice, cockroaches, and bedbugs; and ev-

GABRIEL HOUSE, Page A10

Mixed blessing

The 59 surviving residents after the fire are slowly having belongings returned, bringing joy and grief. **B1.**



Former WBZ-TV news anchor Kate Merrill asserted in a federal lawsuit that she was forced out of her job over unfounded allegations of racial bias, while her own complaint was ignored. **D1.**

Brown University officials say they are anticipating staff layoffs and other cost-cutting measures to prepare for a \$30 million loss to mitigate the impact of the Trump tax law. **B1.**

Auditor Diana DiZoglio is escalating her legal fight to investigate the Legislature, retaining an attorney to try to force the matter to the courts. **B1.**

A sergeant shot five soldiers at one of the country’s largest Army bases before he was quickly tackled by other Fort Stewart troops, forcing a brief lockdown, officials said. **A2.**



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Weather and Comics, D5-6.

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BARRY CHIN/GLOBE STAFF/FILE

Roman Anthony is guaranteed \$130 million and could make much more. **Red Sox’ winning streak stopped at seven, C1.**

Red Sox banking on Anthony

After fast start, star rookie gets eight-year deal

By Tim Healey and Alex Speier
GLOBE STAFF

Roman Anthony, so touted as a part of the Red Sox’ future, is positioned now as a foundational piece of a very long present.

Anthony and the Red Sox finalized an eight-year contract worth \$130 million, a source confirmed to the Globe on

Wednesday, locking up the 21-year-old rookie outfielder through at least the 2033 season.

The deal will begin next season and includes salary escalators — based on his votes in Rookie of the Year and Most Valuable Player balloting, as well as All-Star appearances — that could boost the value to \$230 million. The Red Sox also hold a club option worth \$30 million for a ninth year, 2034, at which point Anthony will be 30.

“When we think about the future of this organization,

there’s no question that it got brighter today,” chief baseball officer Craig Breslow said.

Anthony played in his 47th major league game Wednesday. His new contract will cover 1,296 games.

“When the offer came through, it was something I wanted to move quickly on,” Anthony said. “There was no doubt this was where I wanted to play baseball for a long time.”

A hastily called Fenway Park news conference — about 90 minutes before first pitch of the series finale against the Royals

ANTHONY, Page C4